

ELI PEARSON - WRITTEN FOR YOU, NOT ABOUT YOU

November 18th

The plan for the next fifteen years, and why the next nine weeks decide how it starts

You are seventeen. You work hard, you are already paid above what most Baton Rouge labourers your age earn, you can work full time because you are homeschooled, and you own a truck that can pull a trailer. That is a better hand than almost anyone starts with, and nobody handed it to you.

On 18 November every legal restriction on what you can do at work disappears in a single day. Machines, truck, trailer, all of it. This document is about being completely ready for that morning instead of starting to think about it that week.

Every number here comes out of your own workbook, and every one of them is yours to change

Three numbers worth memorising

+\$9.41

an hour - the gap between a Baton Rouge labourer and an equipment operator. About \$19,600 a year, and it costs no money at all. Only seat time, and asking.

\$5,944

a year your truck should earn on top of your wages, tax-free, at 8,000 business miles. You already own the asset. Almost nobody your age does.

18 Nov

the day the machines and the truck unlock. Nine weeks from now. Everything on the next page is about that date.

Those three numbers are the whole argument. **The first one says the fastest raise of your life is the next one** - not a promotion in ten years, the seat of a machine in the next two. **The second says you are not only a worker here, you are an owner of something the company needs**, and owners get paid differently from workers. **The third says the clock starts in nine weeks.**

Everything else in this document is detail underneath those three things.

The reason this document exists: there is a difference between working FOR a business and working IN one. Working for it means selling your hours. Working in it means understanding where the money comes from, owning something it needs, and being the person other people's plans depend on. You can start the second one at eighteen. Most people never do.

What you can and cannot do until your birthday

This is worth understanding properly rather than being annoyed by, because it ends on a fixed date and there is a smart way to spend the time until then.

Until 18 November you CANNOT	From 18 November you CAN
Run the mini excavator or skid steer to dig or backfill a trench - any depth. The law (29 CFR 570.68) bans under-18s from excavating, working in, or backfilling trenches , and the only exception is HAND digging under four feet.	Operate every machine on the yard, on any job, at any depth, with no restriction at all.
Ride in either machine. That is a separate rule and it catches people out.	Ride, operate, service, whatever the job needs.
Drive your truck for work, or tow any trailer. Towing under 18 is flatly prohibited - there is no version of it that is allowed.	Drive and tow for the company - and start being paid for the truck.
Use a chain saw, cut-off saw or chipper; run a forklift or a skid steer with forks on it.	All of it.
What you CAN do now: hand-dig and hand-backfill under four feet, carry and lay pipe, shovel and wheelbarrow gravel, lay and repair sod, hand tools, setup, cleanup. That is a real full-time job at \$20 an hour.	And one piece of paper to sort now: Louisiana requires an employment certificate for anyone under 18. Because you are homeschooled it comes from the East Baton Rouge Parish superintendent's office rather than a principal. Getting it without being asked is the first small thing on the list - and the kind of thing that gets you trusted with bigger ones.

Nine weeks is not a delay. It is a head start, if you spend it learning the machines with the engine off, getting the OSHA card, and sorting the truck out - so that on the morning of the 18th you are the person who is already ready, not the person who starts thinking about it.

What each step pays, and what it costs to get there

Every rate below is in **today's dollars** so you can compare it to what you earn right now. The workbook also shows them grown for inflation, which makes the later years look bigger.

Age	What you are	Rate	A year	What you get that year
18	Laborer -> machines unlock 18 Nov	\$20.00	\$41,600	Turning 18 unlocks every machine and the truck. OSHA 10. Trenching competent-person card. Louisiana employment certifi
19	Laborer / operator trainee	\$23.00	\$47,840	CDL Class A at BRCC - 6 weeks, \$5,640.
20	Equipment operator	\$26.00	\$54,080	OSHA 30. Open the LLC and the business bank account.
22	Senior operator	\$30.00	\$62,400	Build a clean credit file. Secured card, paid in full, every month.
25	Assistant foreman	\$36.00	\$74,880	LSLBC Class 13 licence - minimum age 18, no experience requirement, \$10,000 net worth or a bond in lieu.
26	Foreman	\$38.51	\$80,101	First machine, if the numbers work. Used mini-ex, 2-3.5 tonne.
28	Superintendent	\$44.00	\$91,520	Second machine or a partner's stake.
30	Operations lead / partner	\$50.00	\$104,000	Either a real stake here, or your own company.
32	Owner	\$58.00	\$120,640	Consider adding LSLBC Class 62 - docks, piers, bulkheads. The water work.

Look at the jump between 18 and 20. That is not a promotion anybody gives you - it is the machine seat, and it is the single highest-return thing you will ever do with your time. Everything after it is a slower climb. Which is why the plan is: get in the seat early, then start learning what things cost.

Your truck is a business, not a favour

How this should work

- **The company reimburses you per business mile at the IRS rate** - 72.5 cents a mile January to June 2026, 76 cents from July. That rate exists because the government calculated what a mile actually costs in fuel, tyres, repairs, insurance and wear.
- **Done properly, that money is completely tax-free to you.** It is not wages. It does not go on a W-2. No income tax, no Social Security, no Medicare. You keep every dollar - and the company still deducts every dollar. Both sides genuinely win.
- The rule that makes it tax-free is simple: the miles have to be for work, you have to write them down as you go, and you cannot claim your drive from home to the yard. Keep a log from day one. Reconstructing it in April does not count.
- At 8,000 business miles that is **\$5,944 a year**. Your actual running cost on a paid-off truck is around \$2,800, so you genuinely clear about **\$3,144**.
- **And ask before you start, not after.** Asking up front is businesslike. Asking six months in, after doing it for free, sounds like a complaint. Same money, completely different conversation - and that distinction is worth more to learn than the money itself.

Read this twice before you tow anything

Your personal car insurance almost certainly does not cover using the truck for business. Nearly every personal policy excludes it, and towing a machine on a trailer for a paying job is squarely business use.

If you wreck on a work trip and they find out, the realistic outcome is they deny the claim and then decline to renew you. You would be paying for a wrecked truck yourself, at eighteen, and then shopping for insurance as a young driver with a cancellation on your record.

Before you tow anything for work: call your own insurer and tell them exactly what the truck will be used for; get the answer in writing; and ask Charlie to confirm the company carries hired and non-owned auto coverage - which protects the company, not your truck. If your carrier will not cover business use, price a commercial policy *before* you start.

This is the most important paragraph in the whole document. Everything else here is about making money. This one is about not losing what you already own.

Getting paid for something you own, separately from getting paid for your time, is the whole idea behind working in a business rather than for one. Your truck is where you get to learn it - with a small asset, at eighteen, where the stakes are low and the lesson is permanent.

The next nine weeks

When	What you do	Why it matters
This week	Get the Louisiana employment certificate from the EBR superintendent's office; give Charlie a copy.	Legally required while you are 17, and the only thing protecting Charlie if anyone ever asks. Doing it without being chased is the kind of thing that gets you trusted with bigger things.
This week	Start the job notebook. Every day: what job, what you did, how long, what materials, what went wrong.	In three years this is what lets you estimate. Nobody can teach you what a job should cost - you can only have written down what it did cost, over and over.
This week	Call your insurance company about the truck.	See the previous page. This is the one that can actually hurt you.
Weeks 1-4	Do OSHA 10 online - about \$60-90 and a few evenings.	Cheap, permanent, and it makes you the obvious person to trust near a trench at eighteen.
Weeks 2-6	Learn the machines with the engine off . Every control, every service point, the daily checks.	You cannot legally operate yet - but nothing stops you from knowing the machine cold. On the 18th you want to be the one who already knows where everything is.
Weeks 4-8	Get the trenching competent-person card. \$49-200.	OSHA requires a designated competent person on trenching work. Holding it is the fastest way to stop being the youngest guy and start being necessary.
Weeks 6-9	Sort the truck: tow rating, trailer wiring and brakes checked, insurance answered in writing.	So the truck can start earning on the 18th rather than waiting on a wiring harness.
Weeks 6-9	Ask Charlie how the truck gets paid for - mileage at the IRS rate, agreed in writing.	Before you start. Not after.
18 November	Birthday. Everything unlocks. Ask for the machine seat that week.	Not in January. The operator premium is \$9.41 an hour and every month you wait is roughly \$1,600 you did not earn.
After	Track one number for Charlie nobody asked you to track: linear feet per crew day.	Bringing an owner a number he did not ask for is how an eighteen-year-old becomes someone the business gets built around.

You are standing next to three educations

Who	What they know that you do not	How to actually get it
Charlie	Selling and estimating. Why a homeowner picks one contractor over another, how to price a job, how to read what somebody actually wants. He has done every job in this company himself.	Ride along on estimates and say nothing. Afterwards ask one question: <i>why did you price it that way?</i> Owners will teach almost anybody who is genuinely curious and not trying to look clever.
Bryan	Running people. Scheduling a day so nobody stands around, keeping crews, safety, job costing. Twenty-five years of it, plus running a bar - which is a harder people business than this one.	Ask how he decides who does what each morning. Then ask what he would do differently if he started over. People who have run something love that question and almost nobody asks it.
Me	The business side. Numbers, structure, how deals get put together, how systems make a small company punch above its size.	Learn to read a P&L and understand where the money actually goes. Ask me to walk you through your workbook line by line - the thing you are holding <i>is</i> the lesson.
The suppliers	Every aggregate and pipe vendor knows every contractor in the parish and who pays on time. Terms from a supplier are working capital you did not have to borrow.	Learn their names, be at the counter early, never be the one arguing about an invoice. In five years a supplier who trusts you is worth more than a bank line - and they are deciding that now, watching how you behave at eighteen.
Other trades	Plumbers, roofers, gutter installers, landscapers, realtors. They stand in the same yards you do and they see the drainage problems first.	Be useful to them with nothing expected back. Referrals flow along relationships, not advertising, and the ones that matter get built years before they pay.
A banker	What a lender needs to see before they will back a twenty-five-year-old with a plan.	Open a business account before you need one and meet an actual person at the branch. Lenders back people they have watched for a while. Starting that clock at eighteen costs nothing.

The part that actually decides it

Seven things, and they are not complicated

- **Answer the phone.** In residential work being the one who picks up is a real competitive advantage, and it is free. Most contractors do not.
- **Do what you said, when you said.** Nearly all of business reputation is this one thing, repeated for years.
- **Write it down.** Change orders, promises, prices, what the customer asked for. Contractors go broke doing unpaid extra work they agreed to verbally.
- **Never spend the tax money.** Set it aside the week it comes in. More small businesses die of this than of bad work.
- **Be early.** The cheapest possible way to signal you are serious, and at your age it gets noticed more than anything you say.
- **Own mistakes fast and completely.** The people who go furthest are not the ones who never break a sprinkler line - they are the ones who say so before the customer finds it.
- **Be someone people want to help.** Almost everything good in a trade arrives through somebody who decided to put your name forward. They decide that watching how you behave when nothing is at stake.

And the honest part

This plan works whether you stay with Charlie forever, go out on your own at twenty-six, or do something none of us has thought of. That is deliberate. Every single thing on the ladder - the machine seat, the licences, the notebook, the relationships, knowing what a job costs - is **yours**. None of it belongs to a company, and none of it can be taken off you.

What I am not going to pretend: this work is hard on a body, construction has a fatality rate nearly three times the average across all jobs, and trenching is among the most dangerous parts of it. The plan deliberately moves you off the shovel and toward the estimate, the truck and the ownership side by about thirty. That is not going soft. It is the same move that protects you from automation, and it is the same move that lets you still be working at fifty.

There is no version of this where you get handed anything. There is a version where at thirty you own machines, hold licences, know every supplier in the parish and decide who works for you. The distance between those two is about a decade of showing up early and writing things down.

Start the notebook this week. Everything else on these eight pages is downstream of that one habit.